

LOOKS.TASTES.SENSATIONS

KEVIN O'NEILL

You simply can't have a top party without him

Flamboyant Melbourne florist Kevin O'Neill has dressed some of the top parties in Australia and even one in Berlin. KEITH DUNSTAN reports.

IT'S interesting how nobody ever turns out quite as expected. Kevin O'Neill isn't trendy with bleached hair, one earring and black leather trousers. He's a neat, sober gentleman, smallish with brown hair. He could be the secretary of a conservative trustee company or, with that moustache, an adjutant with three pips working at army headquarters. But Kevin O'Neill is Australia's top florist.

If you were having Prince Charles, Diana, Malcolm, Lady Potter or even Bob to dinner, it would be unthinkable not to have Kevin. If your daughter was getting married in Perth, it would be reasonable to send the Learjet for Kevin's arrangements. When Rupert Murdoch was battling in Berlin in June to get the Olympic Games for Brisbane, what did he do? Sent for Kevin.

At the time of the interview Kevin was quite desperately busy. He was doing a birthday party on a boat in Sydney — lunch for 300 people. There would be plants in baskets, hundreds of them. Then on the tables there would be trees with gorgeous autumn maple leaves and tied in to those branches he would have pomegranates. Peter Rowlands, of Melbourne, was doing the food and the whole lot was going up in a whopping semi-trailer. He would fly up with three of the staff.

The same day, fortunately in the evening, he was doing a party in Melbourne. Harry The Hirer was providing the marquee. Melburnians, Kevin says, adore parties at home. "Maybe it's the climate. Sydney people prefer the yacht club or whatever."

The marquee was a huge dome with no poles. Everything inside was pink. All over the ceiling there was lolly-pink material and, behind that, tens of thousands of tiny lights.

There would be pale pink tablecloths with deep pink throw-overs and, to set

off that pinkness, purple grapes and peaches. Bacci chocolates would be there, too, as long as they were the right colour.

The flowers? They would be branches of pink magnolia and pink jasmine. As the guests came in, smoke machines would be wafting mysterious clouds across the disco.

"First impression," Kevin said, "is everything. When they enter that marquee they know — the chances are nine out of 10 — they are going to have a good time." And laughing he added, "Peter Rowlands says if they feel good when they enter the marquee they don't worry so much about the food."

Talking to Kevin O'Neill, at his headquarters in South Yarra, is an experience. The air is heady with the smell of deep burgundy long-stemmed roses. All around are orchids from Singapore. Beyond are tulips from Holland. To my right there is a great basket of gigantic apricot-coloured banksias, something new from Western Australia.

In the window there is a shipment of exotic flowers from Honolulu, bigger than strelitzia with flowers like scarlet sugar-scoops, priced from \$6 to \$50 each.

"It's unlikely that I will ever sell them," said Kevin. "It's just wonderful to have them in the shop."

Kevin O'Neill, now in his 40s, grew up in Hawthorn and went to a Seventh Day Adventist private school. "My mother is very garden conscious," he said, "and did the flowers for the church. She used to be a client of florist John Holdsworth. He told her he had a vacancy for someone to start there."

"Would you like to work with John Holdsworth?", she said. I didn't want to be a florist. At school I wasn't good at anything that mattered. I mean, I liked the arts and I was good with my hands. "Give it a try," she said. So I did. I loved the work. Loved the people. I stayed with John Holdsworth until he died in 1960. Then I opened in South Yarra about 12 years ago. It just took off immediately."

There was a supper party given by Dale Harper for Prince Charles before she became Dale Tryon — 5m branches

of pink dogwood filled with tiny lights; great strawberry tint lanterns hanging over the pool.

There were frequent trips to Canberra on behalf of the Frasers to do the flowers at the Lodge. Traditional flowers, really, suited that house, mainly cream and apricot and yellow. Queen Elizabeth II always adored roses. Once for Queen

Elizabeth II there was a trial party beforehand; flowers, wine, food, all had to be done twice.

"I remember," Kevin said, "going there when Queen Elizabeth was opening Parliament."

"We walked into the foyer of Parliament House and there, right in front of us, was a jam tin sitting on the

reception desk with some half-dead dahlias in it. It wasn't quite the image we were trying to project."

Clients come from all over the continent. He is discreet about names. There was a very big party in Western Australia.

"They asked for a price. It's no more expensive getting flowers over there. It's

the air freight that puts up the cost. We phoned with the price and they said: 'That's ridiculous, we'll send our Learjet over for the flowers.'

"So everything went over in the jet — marquee, props, roses, tuberoses, lilliums, Singapore orchids — and everything was flown back again four days later." Kevin did CHOGM, a big job. ▽



TONY FEDER